

The Sūtra of Brahma's Net

Brahmajāla Sūtra · Toh 352 · Derge Kangyur

ཚངས་པའི་དྲ་བའི་མེད།

The Brahmajāla Sūtra, known in Tibetan as the Tsangpé Drawé Do (Tshang pa'i dra ba'i mdo), or "The Sūtra of Brahma's Net," is a discourse in which the Buddha, traveling through Magadha with a large assembly of monks, laypeople, and wandering mendicants, sets out an extensive analysis of the views held by various religious teachers of his day. The text takes its evocative title from the image of Brahmā's celestial net, whose countless jeweled nodes serve as a metaphor for the interconnected web of speculative doctrines — concerning the self, the world, and ultimate existence — that the Buddha systematically examines and transcends. It belongs to a class of early sūtra literature concerned with distinguishing the Buddha's teaching from the philosophical and ascetic movements of ancient India, and it is particularly notable for its detailed enumeration of sixty-two wrong views. This work is Toh 352 in the Kangyur, where it is preserved among the sūtra collections.

In the language of India: Brahmajāla Sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Sūtra of Brahma's Net. Homage to the Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was traveling through the land of Magadha together with a great Saṅgha of monks numbering one thousand two hundred and fifty monks, together with one thousand laymen and five hundred wandering mendicants. While journeying in that way, one night he took up residence with the monastic Saṅgha at a royal rest-house lying between Rājagṛha and the village of Ambalatthikā.

At that time, the wanderer Suppiya, by way of many arguments and formulations, was speaking disparagingly of the Buddha, and likewise speaking disparagingly of the Dharma and the Saṅgha. Meanwhile, the wanderer Suppiya's own pupil, a brahmin's son named Brahmadatta, was by way of many arguments and formulations speaking in praise of the Buddha, and likewise speaking in praise of the Dharma and the Saṅgha. Thus teacher and pupil, those two, disagreed and spoke at odds with one another in their views, their dispositions, their analyses, and their judgments, and they followed along in the very footsteps of the Saṅgha of monks and of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha.

Then the many monks who had gathered and assembled at the royal rest-house said among themselves: "Venerable ones, how wondrous is the variety of dispositions among sentient beings! For here is the wanderer Suppiya who, by way of many arguments and formulations, speaks disparagingly of the Buddha, and likewise speaks disparagingly of the Dharma and the Saṅgha; while the wanderer Suppiya's own pupil, the brahmin's son called Brahmadata, by way of many arguments and formulations speaks in praise of the Buddha, and likewise speaks in praise of the Dharma and the Saṅgha. Thus teacher and pupil, those two, speak at odds with one another in their views, their dispositions, their analyses, and their judgments, and they follow along in the very footsteps of the Saṅgha of monks and of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha. How utterly remarkable this is!" Such were the timely words they rightly uttered there.

Then the Blessed One, resting in daytime retreat, heard through his purified divine hearing, surpassing that of human faculties, those timely words of the many monks gathered and assembled at the royal rest-house. Having heard, he arose from that meditative absorption, went to the royal rest-house, had a seat set out there before the assembly of monks, and sat down. Having sat down, he addressed the monks: "Monks, you many monks gathered and assembled here at the royal rest-house — what were the timely words that arose among you? For what reason are you now gathered here?"

"Venerable One, we many monks were gathered here at this royal rest-house, and the wanderer Suppiya, by way of many arguments and formulations, was speaking disparagingly of the Buddha, and likewise speaking disparagingly of the Dharma and the Saṅgha; while the wanderer Suppiya's pupil, the brahmin's son called Brahmadata, by way of many arguments and formulations was speaking in praise of the Buddha, and likewise speaking in praise of the Dharma and the Saṅgha. Thus teacher and pupil, those two, spoke at odds with one another in their views, their dispositions, their analyses, and their judgments, and they followed in the very footsteps of the Saṅgha of monks and of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha. We were saying, 'How utterly remarkable this is!' — and such were the timely words we had raised among ourselves."

"Venerable ones, the timely words that arose among us while we, many monks, were gathered together at the royal residence — those are precisely the words that have now brought us together here.

Monks, when someone speaks ill of me, or speaks ill of the Dharma and the Saṅgha, do not harbor ill will toward them. Do not become impatient. Do not become hostile. Do not become inwardly displeased. Monks, if, when someone speaks ill of me, or speaks ill of the Dharma and the Saṅgha, you were to harbor ill will, impatience, hostility, or inner displeasure, that would become nothing but an obstacle for you. For why? Because if a monk were to become angry, agitated, and resentful, falling into displeasure, it would then be utterly impossible for him to know and see whether everything that other person has said is correct and complete. Therefore, monks, when someone speaks ill of me or speaks ill of the Dharma and the Saṅgha, what is correct should be acknowledged as correct, and what is not correct as not correct, in this way: 'This is not correct, it is not so, and this thing does not exist in our teaching' — that is how one should respond.

Monks, when someone speaks well of me, or speaks well of the Dharma and the Saṅgha, do not be elated. Do not be mentally gratified. Do not let your mind become puffed up with pride. Monks, if, when someone speaks well of me or speaks well of the Dharma and the Saṅgha, you were to become elated, mentally gratified, or puffed up with pride, that would become nothing but an obstacle for you. For why? Because if a monk were to become elated, mentally gratified, or puffed up with pride, it would then be utterly impossible for him to know and see whether everything that other person has said is correct and complete. Therefore, monks, when someone speaks well of me or speaks well of the Dharma and the Saṅgha, what is correct should be acknowledged as correct, and what is not correct as not correct, in this way: 'This is not correct, it is not so, and this thing does not exist in our teaching' — that is how one should respond.

Monks, those childish, ordinary people (pṛthagjana) who are without learning — what they say and speak in praise of the Tathāgata amounts to only a small thing, and only to moral discipline (śīla) and matters far removed from desire. And how is it only moral discipline? Gautama has expansive moral discipline; he speaks as he acts, and he acts as he speaks. Gautama has thus abandoned the taking of life and has turned back from the taking of life: he has compassion for all living sentient beings, knows shame, has put down the rod and the weapon, and has abandoned the taking of life down to and including insects. Gautama has thus abandoned taking what is not given and has turned back from taking what is not given: he does not take what is not given, he takes delight in what is freely given — and likewise in much else of this kind.

Just as certain ascetics (śramaṇas) and brahmins consume in full what has been given to them out of faith, while others whose knowledge is bent live by wrong livelihood — such as the ripening of karmic results of traveling on the paths of the sun and moon, traveling on the reversed paths of the sun and moon, the direction-blazing that arises from falling stars, the sounds of divine drums from the sky — that sort of ripening of results."

the reversed paths of the sun and moon, the direction-blazing that arises from falling stars, the sounds of divine drums from the sky — and moreover the sun and moon being as powerful as they are, as possessed of great magical potency as they are — karmic maturation of this kind is as follows: not knowing the rising and setting, the defilement and purification, the establishing and arrangement of these things is due to following the path and the reversed path. Gautama has abandoned such wrong livelihood, the wrong livelihood practiced by those whose knowledge is bent.

How is it that he is utterly secluded from sensual pleasures? Gautama is endowed with these aggregates of noble moral discipline, dwells in the restraint of the sense faculties, is constantly mindful through mindfulness guarding all, and through mindfulness guards the mind completely, settling it in a state of balance. When he looks upon forms with the eye, he takes no characteristic as his mark, and he has taken up the vow of restraint right up to the faculty of the mind.

Gautama is endowed with this aggregate of moral discipline and this restraint of the sense faculties, and he dwells with vigilance while going and coming, and dwells with vigilance from the act of looking and gazing all the way to dispelling drowsiness with sleep.

Gautama is endowed with this aggregate of noble moral discipline and this restraint of the sense faculties, and because he is endowed with this supreme mindfulness and vigilance, dwelling at ease on his resting mat he becomes secluded from sensual pleasures, secluded from sinful and unwholesome phenomena, and with applied thought and sustained thought, with the joy and ease born of seclusion, he dwells having accomplished and entered into the first meditative concentration. Such is seclusion from sensual pleasures.

Monks, those phenomena that are profound, appearing profound, utterly pure, utterly cleansed — having fully and completely awakened to them through my own direct knowledge, I have taught them, and those on the other side as well speak and proclaim what is truly praiseworthy of the Tathāgata, just as it is

and as it ought to be.

Monks, what are those phenomena that are profound, appearing profound, utterly pure, utterly cleansed — which, having fully and completely awakened to them through my own direct knowledge, I have taught, and which those on the other side speak and proclaim as truly praiseworthy of the Tathāgata, just as it is and as it ought to be?

Monks, there are some ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past limit, who declare and proclaim: "The self and the world are permanent" — and this rests on four grounds.

On what basis, depending on what, standing on what, do those wise ascetics and brahmins who proclaim permanence speculate about the past limit and declare and proclaim: "The self and the world are permanent"? This rests on those four grounds.

Monks, here certain ascetics and brahmins — whether dwelling in the wilderness, dwelling at the foot of a tree, or dwelling in an empty house — come to touch a meditative absorption of that kind, a samādhi in which the mind is stilled, arising from the cause of striving, arising from the cause of relinquishment, arising from the cause of meditation, arising from the cause of repeated application, and arising from the cause of correct attention. With the mind thus placed in meditative equipoise, they rightly and correctly recollect twenty cosmic eons of destruction and formation. They then think: "For this reason the self and the world are permanent." And thus thinking: "Whether I dwell in the wilderness, dwell at the foot of a tree, or dwell in an empty house — arising from the cause of striving, arising from the cause of relinquishment, arising from the cause of meditation, arising from the cause of repeated application,

and arising from the cause of correct attention, one should reach such a meditative absorption in which the mind is stilled." With the mind thus placed in meditative equipoise, they rightly and correctly recollect twenty cosmic eons of destruction and formation. And thus thinking: "The self and the world are permanent — not moving, not going, not subject to change, standing firm like an iron pillar. And thus these sentient beings who possess consciousness go on running and wandering, but nothing is comparable to that permanence." This is the ground upon which eternalists rely, the basis from which they stand, the position they hold, speculating about the anterior extreme and asserting and proclaiming: "The self and the world are permanent." This is the

first ground.

The second: as for those wise ascetics and brahmins who are eternalists — what they rely upon, what they stand upon, and what position they hold, speculating about the anterior extreme and asserting and proclaiming that the self and the world are permanent — monks, in this case those wise ascetics and brahmins who are eternalists, whether they dwell in the wilderness, dwell at the foot of a tree, or dwell in an empty house, arising from the cause of striving, arising from the cause of relinquishment, arising from the cause of meditation, arising from the cause of repeated application, and arising from the cause of correct attention, reach such a meditative absorption in which the mind is stilled. With the mind thus placed in meditative equipoise, they rightly and correctly recollect forty cosmic eons of destruction and formation. They then think: "For this reason the self and the world are permanent. I myself — whether I dwell in the wilderness, dwell at the foot of a tree, or dwell in an empty house —" and so on, continuing as before up to: the ground upon which eternalists rely, the basis from which they stand, the position they hold, speculating about the anterior extreme and asserting and proclaiming: "The self and the world are permanent." This is the second ground.

The third: as for those wise ascetics and brahmins who are eternalists — what they rely upon, what they stand upon, and what position they hold, speculating about the anterior extreme and asserting and proclaiming that the self and the world are permanent — monks, in this case there are certain ascetics and brahmins who, with the mind thus placed in meditative equipoise, rightly and correctly recollect eighty cosmic eons of destruction and formation — and so forth as before — and thinking: "The self and the world are permanent," and thus: "These sentient beings who possess consciousness go on running and wandering, but nothing is comparable to that permanence." The ground upon which eternalists rely, the basis from which they stand, the position they hold, speculating about the anterior extreme and asserting and proclaiming: "The self and the world are permanent." This is the third ground.

The fourth: as for those wise ascetics and brahmins who are eternalists — what they rely upon, what they stand upon, and what position they hold, speculating about the anterior extreme and asserting and proclaiming that the self and the world are permanent — monks, these ascetics and brahmins are as before. With the mind placed in meditative equipoise, with the divine eye (deva-eye), purified and surpassing that of humans, they see sentient beings dying and being reborn — with beautiful form and with ugly form, with low

station and with distinguished station, going to fortunate destinies and going to unfortunate destinies. And thus thinking: "The self and the world are permanent," the ground upon which eternalists rely, the basis from which they stand, the position they hold —

— speculating about the past and asserting and proclaiming that the self and the world are permanent — this constitutes the fourth ground" — all of this is as before.

Monks, all those ascetics and brahmins who are eternalists, who speculate about the past and assert and proclaim that the self and the world are permanent — all of them do so on the basis of these four grounds, no more and no fewer. Whatever views those who have gone to such views hold in this way, and whatever supreme positions they cling to — all of this the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, and knows even beyond that, exactly as it is. Knowing it thus, he does not cling to it as supreme. And because he does not cling to it as supreme, he has realized nirvāṇa within himself. And the destiny of those who have gone to such views — their rebirth, their future life — all of this the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, and knows even beyond that, exactly as it is. The Tathāgata knows it exactly as it is; he knows even beyond that exactly as it is; and yet, knowing it so, he does not cling to it as supreme. And because he does not cling to it as supreme, having realized nirvāṇa within himself, he has understood the cessation of all feelings born of craving, and has fully understood what is to be understood: "This is suffering; this is what leads beyond suffering."

Monks, as for those phenomena that are deep, that appear deep, that are utterly pure and utterly clear — these I have taught, having fully awakened to them by my own direct knowledge; and others too rightly praise and proclaim the Tathāgata for these, exactly as it is. — Monks, "those phenomena that are deep, that appear deep" — all of this is as before.

Monks, there are some ascetics and brahmins who, speculating about the past, assert and proclaim: "Some things are permanent — the self and the world are partly permanent." This is how they speak and proclaim, and it is on the basis of these four grounds. On what do those wise ascetics and brahmins rely, on what do they stand, on what do they take their position, when, speculating about the past, they assert and proclaim: "Some things are permanent — the self and the world are permanent"? It is on the basis of these four grounds.

Monks, when the time comes for this world to dissolve, and the world is dissolving, most sentient beings are reborn in the class of the gods of the Ābhāsvara — the gods of Radiant Light. There they are mind-born, possessed of form, with no deficiency or incompleteness of faculties, endowed with all their major and minor limbs, beautiful in complexion; they travel through the sky by their own power, feed on joy and are nourished by joy, and they remain there for a very long time.

Monks, when the time comes for this world to form again, and the world is forming again, the vast palaces of Brahmā become manifest in the empty sky. Then some being among the gods of Radiant Light, whose lifespan is exhausted, whose karma is exhausted, whose merit is exhausted, passes away from there and is reborn, alone, in those empty palaces of Brahmā. There that being dwells alone, solitary, without companion, for a very long time.

Then, after that being has dwelt there for a very long time, longing arises, and dissatisfaction grows, and the being thinks: "Oh, how fine it would be if other sentient beings of equal fortune were to be born here!" And with that very aspiration of mind, some other sentient being from the class of the gods of Radiant Light — whose lifespan is exhausted, whose karma is exhausted, whose merit is exhausted — passes away from there and is reborn in those palaces of Brahmā as that being's equal in fortune.

Then that being thinks: "I have dwelt here alone, solitary, without companion, for a very long time. Having dwelt here so long, longing has arisen in me and dissatisfaction has grown. Oh, how fine it would be if other sentient beings of equal fortune were to be born here!" And with that very aspiration of mind, when these sentient beings are born here as equals in fortune, that being thinks: "These sentient beings were emanated by me. I am the lord and master of these sentient beings and all things, their sovereign, the maker, the one who brings them forth, the one who causes their arising."

And those other sentient beings in turn think: "We see that this being dwelt here alone, solitary, without companion, for a very long time. Having dwelt there so long, longing arose and dissatisfaction grew, and that being thought: 'Oh, how fine it would be if other sentient beings of equal fortune were to be born here!' — and with that aspiration of mind, we were born here as equals in fortune to that being. Therefore we were emanated by that being. That being is the lord and master of us and all things, the sovereign, the maker, the one who brings forth, the one who causes arising."

Then some being whose lifespan is exhausted, whose karma is exhausted, whose merit is exhausted, passes away from that place and is reborn here as a human being. And because that being's faculties are fully matured and come to ripeness, he shaves his hair and beard, dons the saffron robe, and goes forth from home into homelessness with genuine and heartfelt faith. Dwelling whether in a forest hermitage, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling, he applies himself through the cause of striving, through the cause of renunciation, through the cause of meditation, through the cause of repeated practice, and through the cause of right attention, and thereby attains to a meditative absorption of that kind — one of mental stillness and calm. From that state of mind thus evenly placed in meditative equipoise, he correctly recollects his former existence. And he thinks: "That Brahmā is the lord and master of all things, the sovereign, the maker, the emanator, the one who brings forth, the one who causes arising. He is permanent, stable, everlasting, and possessed of a nature that does not change. But we, having been emanated by that Brahmā, are impermanent, unstable, unreliable, and possessed of a nature that is subject to change."

In this way, some hold that some things are permanent and some are impermanent. Based on what, resting on what, established in what do certain of those who reflect on the prior end — certain ascetics (śramaṇas) and brahmins with learning — assert and declare: "The self and the world are partly permanent"? That is the first basis.

The second: certain ascetics and brahmins with learning, based on what, resting on what, established in what, reflect on the prior end and assert and declare: "The self and the world are partly permanent." The view of that Brahmā is of this kind. The declaration is of this kind, and is expressed in these words: "Earth, water, fire, and wind are impermanent, unstable, unreliable, and possessed of a nature subject to change. But that which is called mind, or mentation, or consciousness — that is permanent, stable, everlasting, and not possessed of a nature subject to change."

Furthermore, when certain sentient beings whose lifespan is exhausted, whose karma is exhausted, and whose merit is exhausted pass away from that realm and come to be reborn here on equal footing with human beings, and when their sense faculties have fully ripened and matured, they shave their hair and beard, don saffron robes, and with genuine faith go forth from home into homelessness. They dwell whether in a forest retreat, at the root of a tree, or in an empty dwelling. Through what arises from the cause of striving, what

arises from the cause of relinquishment, what arises from the cause of meditation, what arises from the cause of repeated practice, and what arises from the cause of right mental application, they reach a meditative absorption in which the mind is at peace. While thus abiding in equipoise, they think: "Brahmā is seen and experienced, and accordingly one says this: earth, water, fire, and wind are impermanent, unstable, unreliable, and possessed of a nature subject to change." And again one says: "That which is called mind, or mentation, or consciousness — that is permanent, stable, everlasting, and not possessed of a nature subject to change."

Thus, some are permanent and some are impermanent. Based on what, resting on what, established in what, they reflect on the prior end and assert and declare: "The self and the world are partly permanent." This is the second basis.

The third: certain ascetics and brahmins with learning, based on what, resting on what, established in what, reflect on the prior end and assert and declare: "The self and the world are partly permanent." This, monks, refers to those gods in the desire realm called "Revelers in Play." When those beings among them who are in a state of great delight and rapture, abiding together in such delight and rapture — when their bodies become fatigued and their mindfulness grows confused, some sentient being whose mindfulness is present passes away from that realm and is reborn here. And so it happens that certain sentient beings whose lifespan is exhausted, whose karma is exhausted, and whose merit is exhausted pass away from that realm and come to be reborn here on equal footing with human beings. When their sense faculties have fully ripened and matured, they shave their hair and beard, don saffron robes, and with genuine faith go forth from home into homelessness. They dwell whether in a forest retreat, at the root of a tree, or in an empty dwelling. Through what arises from the cause of striving, what arises from the cause of relinquishment, what arises from the cause of meditation, what arises from the cause of repeated practice, and what arises from the cause of right mental application, they reach just such a meditative absorption in which the mind is at peace. While thus abiding in equipoise, they recall that previous existence and think: "Those among the gods of the desire realm called 'Revelers in Play' who were abiding without being fully endowed with delight and rapture — they are permanent, stable, everlasting, and possessed of a nature that does not change. But as for us, who were abiding with minds fully possessed of delight and rapture — we are impermanent, unstable, not

everlasting, unreliable, and possessed of a nature subject to change."

Thus, some are permanent and some are impermanent. Based on what, resting on what — and so on as before. This is the third basis.

The fourth: certain ascetics and brahmins with learning, based on what, resting on what, established in what, reflect on the prior end and assert and declare: "The self and the world are partly permanent"—

"The self and the world are partly permanent" — those who assert and declare this: monks, there are, in the desire realm (kāmadhātu), gods called the Mentally Agitated. When they gaze at one another with sharp, fixed stares, those beings become mentally agitated and mentally enraged, and as a result they die and pass away from that realm. But if some being who has exhausted his lifespan, exhausted his karma, and exhausted his merit dies and passes away from that realm and is reborn here among humans — and then, as his faculties fully ripen and mature — from that point through "he recollects his previous bodies accurately" — all of this proceeds as before. He reflects: "Among those gods called the Mentally Agitated in the desire realm, those who did not gaze at one another with sharp, fixed stares — they are permanent, stable, everlasting, and possessed of a nature that does not change. But as for us, who possessed sharp, fixed staring gazes — we are impermanent, unstable, unreliable, and possessed of a nature subject to change."

Thus some are permanent and some are impermanent. Based on what, resting on what — and so on as before. This is the fourth basis. And all those ascetics and brahmins who, reflecting on the prior end, assert and declare "the self and the world are partly permanent" — all of them do so by means of these four bases and no more, no fewer. That the Tathāgata knows perfectly and correctly those who have gone into such views and hold them in such a way — all of this proceeds as before.

Monks, what are those Dharmas — profound, appearing profound, perfectly pure, perfectly clear — that I have taught after awakening to them through my own direct knowledge, and concerning which those on the other side likewise speak accurately and in praise of the Tathāgata? Monks, there are certain ascetics and brahmins who reflect on the prior end and hold the doctrine of arising without cause — who assert and declare: "The self and the world arise from no cause." This belongs to the two bases.

Monks, those learned ascetics and brahmins — based on what, resting on what, established in what — reflecting on the prior end, hold the doctrine of

arising without cause, asserting and declaring: "The self and the world arise from no cause." This belongs to these two bases.

Monks, in the form realm (*rūpadhātu*), because perception arises in the gods of the non-percipient sentient beings, those beings die and pass away from that realm. And if some being dies and passes away from that realm and is reborn here among humans — from there through "he accurately recollects the arising of that previous perception" — all of this proceeds as before. He reflects: "The self and the world arise from no cause." Therefore he thinks: "The self and the world arise from no cause, and so I, who previously had not come into being, have now come into being." This is the first basis — and "based on what, resting on what" and so on proceeds as before.

The second basis: the learned ascetics and brahmins — "based on what, resting on what" and so on proceeds as before.

Here, a certain person who is given to speculation, who has entered upon the ground of reasoning, who proceeds from his own ingenuity, who is an ordinary being, who follows in the wake of reasoning, thinks to himself: "The self and the world arise from no cause. Therefore I think: the self and the world arise from no cause, and so I am one given to speculation, who has entered upon the ground of reasoning, who proceeds from his own ingenuity, an ordinary being who follows in the wake of inquiry." This is the second basis, and "based on what, resting on what" and so on proceeds as before.

Monks, whatever ascetics and brahmins there are who speculate about the past and proclaim and declare the arising from no cause — that the self and the world arise from no cause — all of them do so on the basis of these two grounds and no more, no fewer. The Tathāgata knows completely and exactly how those who have gone to such views hold those views and cling to them as supreme. He knows completely and exactly what lies beyond that as well. And because he knows in this way, he does not cling to them as supreme. Not clinging to them as supreme, he knows *nirvāṇa* within himself. He knows completely and exactly, as they really are, the destiny, the birth, and the future life of those who have gone to such views. He knows completely and exactly what lies beyond that as well. And having known them completely and exactly, he does not cling. Not clinging, and knowing *nirvāṇa* within himself, having fully understood the arising and passing away of feelings, he knows: "This is suffering, and this is the leading out from suffering."

Monks, those other teachings that are profound and appear profound — this proceeds as before. Monks, as for those other teachings that are profound and appear profound — down to "what are those teachings?" — this proceeds as before.

Monks, there are certain learned ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past and who assert the doctrine of the finite and the infinite, proclaiming and declaring that the self and the world are neither finite nor infinite. These exist in accordance with four grounds. Those learned ascetics and brahmins, based on what, resting on what, having established what, speculate about the past and assert the doctrine of the finite and the infinite — proclaiming and declaring that the self and the world are both finite and infinite — do so in accordance with four grounds.

Monks, here a certain learned ascetic or brahmin — whether dwelling in a forest, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling — through the cause of diligence, through the cause of renunciation, through the cause of cultivation, through the cause of repeated practice, through the cause of proper attention, attains a meditative absorption of that kind in which the mind is at peace. With the mind thus placed in equipoise, he remains with the perception that the world is finite. He thinks: "The world is finite." Therefore he thinks: "The world is finite and bounded, and so I — whether dwelling in a forest, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling" — and so on, down to "I shall remain with the perception that the world is finite" — this proceeds as before. Thus the view that the world is finite and bounded is the first ground.

The phrase "in dependence on what and abiding in what" proceeds as before.

The second ground: The words "in dependence on what and abiding in what do the knowledgeable ascetics and brahmins" down through "whether dwelling in a forest, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling" — all this proceeds as before. With the mind thus placed in equipoise, he remains with the perception that the world is infinite. He thinks: "The world is infinite and boundless," and therefore he thinks: "I — whether dwelling in a forest, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling" — and so on down to "I shall remain with the perception that the world is infinite, because the world is infinite and boundless." Thus the view that the world is infinite and boundless is the second ground. The rest, down through "in dependence on what and abiding in what," proceeds as before.

The third ground: The words "in dependence on what and abiding in what do the knowledgeable ascetics and brahmins" proceed as before. From "whether dwelling in a forest, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling" down to "with the mind thus placed in equipoise" — he remains with the perception that the world above and below is finite, and the perception that it is infinite across, extending without bound in the horizontal directions. He thinks: "The world above and below is finite, while horizontally it is infinite." Therefore he thinks: "Above and below it is finite; horizontally it is infinite," and so he — whether dwelling in a forest, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling — and so on. This is the third ground. The rest, down through "in dependence on what and abiding in what," proceeds as before.

The fourth ground: Everything from that heading down through "the knowledgeable ascetics and brahmins, in dependence on what and abiding in what" proceeds as before. Here, some knowledgeable ascetics and brahmins — whether dwelling in a forest, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling — with the mind placed in equipoise, remain with the perception that the world is neither finite nor infinite. They think: "This world is neither finite nor infinite." Therefore they think: "The world is neither finite nor infinite," and they — whether dwelling in a forest, at the foot of a tree, or in an empty dwelling — remain with the perception that the world is neither finite nor infinite. Thus the view that the world is neither finite nor infinite is the fourth ground. The rest, down through "in dependence on what and abiding in what," proceeds as before.

All those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past and who assert and declare — "The self and the world are finite," "The self and the world are infinite," and so forth — all of this falls within these four grounds and no more, no fewer. The Tathāgata has perfectly and correctly understood all of this, and he has understood even what lies beyond it, perfectly and correctly. And since he has understood it thus, those who have gone into views — how they hold them, how they cling to them as supreme, how they take them up, and how they conduct themselves in accordance with them — all this proceeds as before. And "monks, there are other phenomena that are deep and appear deep" — this also proceeds as before. And "monks, what are those other phenomena that are deep and appear deep?" — this too proceeds as before.

Monks, there are certain ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past and who neither set aside nor refrain from setting aside what gods and men have not set aside — asking questions and dispatching words in this way. This

rests on four grounds.

On what do the wise among ascetics and brahmins rely, on what do they stand, and on what basis do they, speculating about the past, neither set aside nor refrain from setting aside — asking questions and dispatching words? This, too, rests on four grounds.

Here, certain ascetics and brahmins do not fully understand non-virtue as it actually is, nor do they fully understand virtue, nor suffering, nor the origin of suffering, nor cessation, nor the path as they actually are. And such a person thinks to himself: "I do not fully understand non-virtue as it actually is, nor do I fully understand virtue, suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, or the path as they actually are. Now if there are other ascetics and brahmins who likewise do not fully understand non-virtue as it actually is, nor virtue, nor suffering, nor the origin of suffering, nor cessation, nor the path as they actually are, and if they were to come and question me about non-virtue, or about virtue, suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, or the path — then, were I to declare answers to their questions about non-virtue, and about virtue, suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, and the path, that would make me a liar. And being a liar, that ascetic or brahmin would dread speaking falsehood, would be frightened by speaking falsehood, and, being utterly despised for speaking falsehood, would abide on that ground, in that island, with that shelter, that refuge, that resort." It is through resorting to evasion — asking questions and dispatching words — that such a one, relying on this and standing on this, speculating about the past, neither sets aside nor refrains from setting aside. This is the first ground.

The second ground: "On what do the wise among ascetics and brahmins rely, on what do they stand, and on what basis" — and so forth, as before — "speculating about the past" — and so forth, as before. Here, certain ascetics and brahmins fully understand non-virtue as it actually is — and so forth, as before — "that would make me a liar, and what makes me a liar makes me one who holds a wrong view. And so that wise ascetic or brahmin, dreading wrong view, frightened of wrong view, and utterly despised precisely for holding wrong view, abides on that ground" — and so forth, as before. From "on what do they rely, on what do they stand, and on what basis" through "dispatching words" — this is the second ground.

The third ground: "On what do the wise among ascetics and brahmins rely, on what do they stand, and on what basis, speculating about the past" — and so

forth, as before. Here, certain ascetics and brahmins do not fully understand non-virtue as it actually is, nor virtue — and so forth, as before — "that would make me a liar, and what makes me a liar makes me one who holds a wrong view, and what makes me hold a wrong view makes me one who lacks vigilance. And so that ascetic or brahmin, dreading lack of vigilance, frightened by lack of vigilance, and utterly despised precisely for lack of vigilance, abides on that ground, in that island" — and so on from there,

as far as "sending a blast of words against them — this is the third ground" — and so on, as before. The fourth: "on what do those wise ascetics and brahmins stand, and on what basis" — and so forth, as before. Here, certain ascetics and brahmins are by their very nature dull-witted and stupid. Such a one thinks to himself: "Suppose someone were to come to me, believing there is a world beyond, and were to ask me, 'Is there a world beyond?' — then I ought to declare to him: 'There is a world beyond.' Or suppose he were to ask, 'Is there no world beyond? Is it both existent and non-existent? Is it neither existent nor non-existent? Is the world like this, or is it not? Is it of another kind, or is it not? Is it not so, or is it not? Is it not like this, or is it not? Is it not a world beyond, or is it not? Is it not like this, or is it not?'" That ascetic or brahmin, dreading delusion, frightened by delusion, and utterly despised precisely for delusion, abides on that ground, on that island, on that refuge, on that shelter, on that support. The questioning and the sending of a blast of words — this evasion of gods and men — is the fourth ground; and "on what do they stand, and on what basis" — and so on, as before.

All that speculating about the past, all that evasion of gods and men, and all that sending of blasts of words — all of it falls under these four grounds, neither more nor fewer; and the Tathāgata understood them perfectly and completely, just as they are, and understood even more than that, perfectly and completely. And those who have gone into such views, who hold them and who hold them as supreme — and so on, as before.

Monks, certain ascetics and brahmins speculate about the past and express and proclaim views that relate to the past — all of that falls under these eighteen views, neither more nor fewer — and so on, as before, as far as "and understood even more."

Monks, those other phenomena that are deep, appear deep — and so on, as before.

Monks, what are those other phenomena that are deep, that appear deep? — and so on, as before.

Monks, there are certain ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future and who speak of beings as percipient. Of these, some assert and declare: "Henceforth the self is not percipient" — this is stated in terms of the sixteen grounds.

On what do those wise ascetics and brahmins stand, and on what basis, and with what as their dwelling, so that, speculating about the future and speaking of beings as percipient, they assert and declare: "Henceforth the self is not percipient" — this is in terms of the sixteen grounds.

Monks, there are certain ascetics and brahmins who hold and assert views as follows: "Henceforth the self will be percipient and possessed of form; henceforth the self will be without form; henceforth the self will be both possessed of form and without form; henceforth the self will be neither possessed of form nor without form." And: "Henceforth the self will be percipient and bounded; will be unbounded; henceforth will be both bounded and unbounded;

henceforth will be neither bounded nor unbounded, and yet percipient." And: "Henceforth the self will be percipient and unitary; will be percipient and multiple; will be percipient and of limited scope; will be percipient and of unlimited scope; will be purely blissful; will be purely suffering; will be both blissful and suffering; will be neither blissful nor suffering." All of these, monks, fall within these sixteen grounds — from "in dependence upon what" to "assert and declare" as stated before.

All those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about a future end and speak of the self as percipient — every one of those who assert and declare: "Henceforth the self is percipient" — all of that falls within these sixteen grounds, no more and no less. The Tathāgata knows all of this completely and exactly as it is, and he knows, with full and precise understanding, even beyond that. And having so known, the Tathāgata does not cling. Because he does not cling, he knows within himself the attainment of nirvāṇa, and he comprehends the arising and subsiding of feelings, knowing: "This is suffering; this is what leads to the cessation of suffering."

Monks, those Dharmas that are profound, that appear profound, that are utterly pure, utterly refined — these I have proclaimed after awakening to them through my own direct knowledge, and others rightly praise the Tathāgata accordingly with truthful words.

And what are those Dharmas, monks, that are profound, that appear profound, utterly pure, utterly refined — which I have proclaimed after awakening to them through my own direct knowledge, and which others rightly praise the Tathāgata for with truthful words?

Monks, those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about a future end and speak of the self as percipient — who assert and declare: "Henceforth the self is percipient" — this holds within these eight grounds.

And on what basis, resting upon what, taking what as their foundation, do those learned ascetics and brahmins who speculate about a future end and speak of the self as non-percipient assert and declare: "Henceforth the self is non-percipient"? This too falls within these eight grounds.

Monks, there are ascetics and brahmins who hold and assert views as follows: "Henceforth the self will be possessed of form and percipient; henceforth the self will be without form; will be both possessed of form and without form; will be neither possessed of form nor without form, and yet percipient; henceforth the self will be bounded and percipient; henceforth the self will be unbounded; will be both bounded and unbounded; will be neither bounded nor unbounded, and yet percipient." This is the eighth ground. And as for "in dependence upon what" and so forth, it is the same as before.

Monks, there are ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end and assert a self that is without perception. Some assert and declare outright: "Henceforth the self will be without perception." All such assertions and declarations fall within those eight grounds — no more and no fewer. The Tathāgata has perfectly understood these just as they are, and has perfectly understood what lies beyond them just as it is. And "those who have gone into such views hold them in such a way" — and so forth as before. Monks, the passage beginning "those other phenomena that are profound, that appear profound" — that is as before. Monks, the passage beginning "and what are those other phenomena that are profound, that appear profound" — that is as before.

Monks, there are ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end and assert that the self is neither percipient nor non-percipient. Some assert

and declare outright: "Henceforth the self will be neither percipient nor non-percipient." This falls within those eight grounds. And in dependence upon what, abiding in what, standing upon what, do those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end and assert that the self is neither percipient nor non-percipient — some asserting and declaring outright: "Henceforth the self will be neither percipient nor non-percipient" — do so? It falls within those eight grounds.

Monks, there are ascetics and brahmins who hold and assert such views, declaring: "Henceforth the self will be possessed of form, and neither percipient nor non-percipient; henceforth the self will be without form, and neither percipient nor non-percipient; henceforth the self will be both possessed of form and without form, and neither percipient nor non-percipient; henceforth the self will be neither possessed of form nor without form, and neither percipient nor non-percipient; henceforth the self will be bounded, and neither percipient nor non-percipient; henceforth the self will be unbounded; will be both bounded and unbounded; will be neither bounded nor unbounded, and neither percipient nor non-percipient." All of this falls within those eight grounds. And in dependence upon what, abiding in what, standing upon what, do those who speculate about the future end assert that the self is neither percipient nor non-percipient — asserting and declaring outright: "Henceforth the self will be neither percipient nor non-percipient" — do so? All such assertions and declarations fall within those eight grounds — no more and no fewer. The Tathāgata has perfectly understood these just as they are, and has perfectly understood what lies beyond them just as it is. "Those who have gone into such views" — and so forth as before. Monks, "those other phenomena that are profound, that appear profound" — as before. Monks, "and what are those other phenomena that are profound, that appear profound" — as before.

Monks, there are ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end and hold the doctrine of annihilation. Some assert and declare outright: "Henceforth the self will be annihilated and will cease to exist." This falls within those seven grounds. Monks, in dependence upon what, abiding in what, standing upon what, do those wise ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end and hold the doctrine of annihilation — some asserting and declaring outright: "Henceforth the self will be annihilated and will cease to exist" — do so? This too falls within those seven grounds.

Monks, there are ascetics and brahmins who hold this view and speak in this way: "So long as the self that has form endures, persisting and remaining established in the four great gross elements, it is subject to illness, subject to decay, subject to pain, subject to disease, subject to utter affliction. But one day this self will be completely cut off." This continues, from "the gods who move in the desire realm, the gods who move in the form realm, those formless ones dwelling in the sphere of infinite space, those formless ones dwelling in the sphere of infinite consciousness, those formless ones dwelling in the sphere of nothingness, and those formless ones dwelling in the sphere of neither perception nor non-perception — so long as they persist and remain," up through "this is the seventh ground," just as before. "In dependence upon what, abiding in what, standing upon what, do those who speculate about the future end and hold the doctrine of annihilation assert and declare outright: 'Henceforth the self will be annihilated and will cease to exist'?" Monks, all of those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end and hold the doctrine of annihilation, asserting and declaring outright: "Henceforth the self will be annihilated and will cease to exist" — all of these fall within these seven grounds, no more and no fewer. The Tathāgata knows them all precisely and correctly, exactly as they are — this passage continues just as before.

Monks, as for those other phenomena that are deep and appear deep — this passage continues just as before. Monks, as for those other phenomena that are deep and appear deep, what are they? — this passage continues just as before.

Monks, there are ascetics and brahmins who hold this view and speak in this way: "When the self comes to enjoy and completely indulge in the five strands of sensual pleasure — that alone is the attainment of nirvāṇa in this present life. And when the self, withdrawn from sensual pleasures, has completed and dwells in all four meditative concentrations — that alone is the attainment of nirvāṇa in this present life." This is the fifth ground. "In dependence upon what, abiding in what, standing upon what, do those who speculate about the future end and assert nirvāṇa in this present life assert and declare this outright?" Monks, all of those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end and assert nirvāṇa in this present life, asserting and declaring it outright — all of these fall within these five grounds, no more and no fewer. The Tathāgata knows them precisely and correctly, exactly as they are, and knows even beyond that, precisely and correctly, exactly as they are. That

being so, from "these who have gone into views, who grasp in this way" up through "it is understood" — this passage continues just as before.

Monks, all of those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end, who have gone into views regarding the future end, who assert and declare these views outright — all of these fall within these forty-four views, no more and no fewer. The Tathāgata knows them precisely and correctly, exactly as they are, and knows even beyond that, precisely and correctly, exactly as they are. That being so, from "these who have gone into views, who grasp in this way" up through "it is understood" — this passage continues just as before.

Monks, all of those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end, who have gone into views regarding the future end, who assert and declare these views outright — all of these fall within these forty-four views, no more and no fewer.

no more and no fewer. The Tathāgata knows them precisely and correctly, exactly as they are, and knows even beyond that, precisely and correctly, exactly as they are. That being so, from "these who have gone into views, who grasp in this way" up through "it is understood" — this passage continues just as before.

Monks, all of those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past end, who have gone into views regarding the past end, who assert and declare these views outright, and all of those who speculate about the future end, who have gone into views regarding the future end, who assert and declare these views outright — all of these, without exception, fall within these sixty-two views, no more and no fewer. The Tathāgata knows them precisely and correctly, exactly as they are, and knows even beyond that, precisely and correctly, exactly as they are. And so the Tathāgata knows precisely and correctly, exactly as they are, how those who have gone into these views grasp in this way, take up in this way, and proceed in this way — that a given destiny is such, that a birth is such, that a future life is such. And knowing even beyond that, precisely and correctly, exactly as they are, the Tathāgata does not cling to even that supreme knowledge. Not clinging, he realizes within himself the attainment of nirvāṇa. Understanding that the arising of feelings has ceased, he knows: "This is suffering; this is what leads suffering to its definitive end."

Monks, as for those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past end and who have gone into views regarding the past end, and those who

speculate about the future end and who have gone into views regarding the future end — even though they may imagine they have leaped upward and broken free, all of them remain sitting within the waters of views and have come under the sway of Māra the wicked one, fallen into his hands, subject to whatever sport Māra the wicked one wishes to make of them. They are not fully liberated from Māra's snares.

Monks, consider, for example, skilled fishermen or their apprentices who cast a fine-meshed net into a small shallow pool. Whatever large living creatures there may be that leap up and imagine they have broken free — all of them remain within the water and have come under the sway of the fisherman, fallen into his hands. Know that they are subject to whatever sport the fisherman wishes to make of them.

In just the same way, those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past end and have gone into views regarding the past end, and those who speculate about the future end and have gone into views regarding the future end — even though they may leap up and imagine they have broken free, all of them remain within the waters of views. They have come under the sway of Māra the wicked one and fallen into his hands, subject to whatever sport Māra the wicked one wishes to make of them.

Monks, now among those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past end and who, as eternalists, declare "The self and the world are eternal" — their assertions fall within those four bases. Monks, those ascetics and brahmins who are unlearned, who have become ignorant, who abide in heedlessness and bewilderment — know that they are in the grip of becoming; they are agitated by becoming.

Monks, as for those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the future end — those who assert nirvāṇa in this present life and who assert and declare nirvāṇa in this present life — this extends up through "these four bases." Those ascetics and brahmins who are unlearned, who have become ignorant, who abide in heedlessness and bewilderment — know that of them

they are agitated by becoming.

Monks, as for those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past end and who are eternalists — those who assert and declare "The self and the world are permanent" — this extends up through "these four bases." And that those views, which are possible as arising through dependent origination, should arise otherwise than through dependent origination — this is

impossible.

As for those who assert nirvāṇa in this present life — those who assert and declare nirvāṇa in this present life — this extends up through "these five bases." And that those views, which are possible as arising through dependent origination, should arise otherwise than through dependent origination — this, too, is impossible.

Monks, as for those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the past end and who are eternalists — those who assert and declare in this present life "The self and the world are permanent" — this falls within these four bases. And that feeling, which is possible as arising from the condition of contact, should arise as feeling other than from contact — this is impossible.

As for "those who speculate about the future end" — those who assert and declare nirvāṇa in this present life — this is as follows: it extends up through "these five bases." And that feeling, which is possible as arising from the condition of contact, should arise as feeling other than arising from contact — this is impossible.

Monks, to the extent that one has genuinely and correctly comprehended the arising, the ceasing, the savoring, and the danger of these six sense bases of consciousness exactly as they are — this is, in this way, a more excellent and correct comprehension.

Monks, as for those persons who are afflicted, who keep being reborn, who are accompanied by plague and disease, who ripen in suffering, who in future lives follow the trail of old age and death — the Tathāgata has abandoned all of that and fully known it. Like a palm tree cut off at the root, it is severed at the base; they become such that they will come into existence as a being without appearance, having the nature of not being born again in the future.

When this enumeration of the Dharma was expounded, the great world system of the three-thousandfold universe shook in three ways: it trembled, greatly trembled, and trembled throughout; it stirred, greatly stirred, and stirred throughout; it quaked, greatly quaked, and quaked throughout.

At that time, the venerable Ānanda was seated at the Blessed One's side, holding a fan, fanning the Blessed One, and he addressed the Blessed One thus: "Reverend One, what is the name of this enumeration of the Dharma? How should we hold it?"

"Ānanda, therefore hold this enumeration of the Dharma by the name 'The Net of Causes.' Hold it also by the names 'The Net of Meanings,' 'The Net of Dharmas,' and 'The Net of Brahmā.' Therefore, 'The Net of Brahmā' is the finest word for this enumeration of the Dharma."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those monks rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

Summary verse:

Permanence and singularity, causelessness,
finitude and its opposite, gods and humans who do not renounce,
perception, non-perception,
annihilation, nirvāṇa,
aiming, and all-encompassing —

Translator's Notes

- The place name rendered "the village of Ambalatthikā" follows the Pāli; the Tibetan འཕགས་ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་གྲོང་ཁྱེད་ is a calque of the Pāli Ambalatthikā, meaning "the village with the mango sapling." The term འཕགས་ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་གྲོང་ཁྱེད་ is the standard Tibetan rendering of Pāli "Suppiya," a named wandering ascetic (parivrājaka); the literal Tibetan meaning is "the greatly joyful wanderer," but as it functions as a proper name it is rendered as Suppiya throughout.
- The passage beginning with "the ripening of karmic results of traveling on the paths of the sun and moon" is a list of low-level, worldly prognostication practices — reading celestial omens, interpreting meteor showers, atmospheric thunder attributed to divine drums — condemned as wrong livelihood for ascetics and brahmins. The Tibetan here compresses what in the Pāli Brahmajāla-sutta and its Sanskrit parallels is an extended catalogue of fortune-telling arts. The text as given breaks off mid-list, so the translation preserves that open-ended quality. The phrase "others whose knowledge is bent live by wrong livelihood" renders the contrast between legitimate recipients of offered food and those who earn their living by such omen-reading arts.
- The passage moves without a clear break from the closing of the preceding section into the Buddha's own first-person teaching. The Tibetan abruptly reprints the same sentence about the Tathāgata being praised by outsiders twice in succession; this is likely a scribal dittography, but both occurrences are rendered faithfully as the text stands. The phrase rendered "those on the other side" translates pha rol po, which in this context means outsiders or opponents who nevertheless speak the Tathāgata's praises accurately — a polemical framing preserved from the Pāli Brahmajāla Sutta tradition. The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end; the translation reflects this exactly.
- The fourth ground shifts the basis from recollective samādhi to the divine eye (Iha'i mig, Skt. divyacakṣus), which is a significant doctrinal distinction: instead of recollecting past lives, these practitioners observe the karmic process of death and rebirth directly. The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the close of the fourth ground description, consistent with the continuous sūtra structure of the Brahmajāla-sūtra discourse as found in the Tibetan Dīrghāgama.
- The phrase rendered "leads beyond suffering" translates a term that literally means "what draws out or extracts from suffering," corresponding to the standard doctrinal pair of duḥkha

and its cessation or nirvāṇa; the rendering captures the soteriological meaning without technical distortion.

The gods of Radiant Light render Ābhāsvara, the class of form-realm deities whose role in cosmogonic accounts is standard in Pāli and Sanskrit sources alike; the passage here closely parallels the Brahmajāla Sūtra and Aggañña Sutta cosmogony.

- The passage presents the classical Buddhist account of how the eternalist view arises — the newly reborn human meditator recovers a memory of a previous existence in Brahmā's realm and, misreading that cosmogonic narrative, concludes that Brahmā is a permanent creator-deity. The Tibetan here closely parallels the Pāli Brahmajāla Sutta and the Dīgha Nikāya account. The distinction drawn at the end — between the material elements as impermanent and consciousness as permanent — represents a specific sub-variety of the "partly permanent, partly impermanent" view (*ekaccasassatavāda*), attributed in the Pāli sources to a second class of speculative theorists who have attained the formless absorptions and thus experienced consciousness as comparatively stable and unshifting relative to the body and the physical world.
- The gods called "Revelers in Play" render the Tibetan *lha rtseḍ mos myos*, corresponding to the Sanskrit *Paranirmitavaśavartin* or, more likely here, the *Nirmāṇarati* class; the specific class intended is the gods who delight excessively in their own pleasures to the point of exhaustion. The doctrinal context — some of that class being permanent and some impermanent — tracks the Pāli Brahmajāla Sutta's account of the *Khiddāpadōsika devas*. The Tibetan here has the text break mid-sentence at the fourth basis, which is accurately reflected by the dash at the close of the translation.
- The phrase rendered "those on the other side likewise speak accurately and in praise of the Tathāgata" (འགོད་པས་བརྟན་པ་ལྟར་བཤད་ཅིང་ཆོས་ཀྱི་མཚན་པར་བཏུག་པ་དང་། རྒྱལ་ཁབ་ཀྱི་ཕྱི་ཁོད་ཡོད་པ་དེ་དག་གིས་ཉམས་ཐོས་ཀྱི་མཚན་པར་བཏུག་པ་ལྟར་བཤད་ཅིང་།) is somewhat elliptical; "those on the other side" (འགོད་པས་བརྟན་པ་ལྟར་བཤད་ཅིང་།) here likely refers to opponents or outside critics who nonetheless, when accurately describing the Tathāgata's teaching, speak correctly — a standard formula in the Brahmajāla Sutta context indicating that even adversaries who praise the Tathāgata only praise these relatively surface qualities, whereas the truly profound Dharmas go deeper. The passage repeats the formula twice in quick succession, which is faithful to the source text's repetition.
- The phrase rendered "neither finite nor infinite" in the opening summary and "both finite and infinite" in the detailed exposition reflects a deliberate and doctrinally significant oscillation in the source text: the summary statement uses the negation form (*mtha' yod pa'ang ma yin*, *mtha' med pa'ang ma yin* — "neither finite nor infinite"), while the detailed exposition shifts to the affirmative (*mtha' yod pa'ang yin*, *mtha' med pa'ang yin* — "both finite and infinite"). This is not an error; it reflects the two ways of characterizing the antinomian position, and both formulations are standard in the Pali parallels (the Brahmajāla Sutta's *amarāvikkhepavādins* and the finite-infinite speculators). The translation preserves this distinction faithfully.
- The phrase rendered "no more, no fewer" translates the Tibetan "*de las mi lhag mi mang,*" literally "not exceeding those, not more than those," a standard scholastic formula meaning that the classification is exhaustive and exact. The doctrinal point is that the Tathāgata's understanding encompasses and surpasses all four positions without being entangled in any of them — a standard Dīghanikāya (Brahmajāla Sutta) theme carried through the Tibetan commentary here.
- The phrase rendered "dispatching words" translates Tibetan meaning something like "sending forth talk or speech" — a term for making verbal pronouncements or issuing statements. The context makes clear this refers to the evasive practice of neither affirming nor denying, issuing verbal deflections rather than direct answers, a position the text identifies with what is known in Pāli sources as *amarāvikkhepavāda*, the "eel-wriggling" or evasive doctrine.

- The passage is a segment of the *Brahmajāla-sūtra* or a closely related *Dīgha-nikāya* parallel (likely the *Brahmajāla* in Tibetan translation), cataloguing the speculative views about the future self (*aparanta-kappika*), specifically the sixteen grounds for asserting the self as non-percipient after death, followed by the opening of the list of views on the self as percipient with form, without form, and so on. The evasion-doctrine passage (the "eel-wiggler" or *amarāvikkhepa* in Pāli) corresponds to the fourth ground of evasion in the Tibetan text. The translation follows the internal Tibetan logic; the formulaic repetitions "as before" render the Tibetan convention of abbreviated redaction throughout.

- The passage cycles through a matrix of views combining the "neither percipient nor non-percipient" formula with the form/formless and bounded/unbounded permutations already established. The Tibetan is highly repetitive and formulaic, as is characteristic of this sūtra genre; the translation preserves the structural repetition faithfully. The shift from "eight grounds" to "seven grounds" at the close, when the annihilationist views begin, follows the Pāli parallel in the Brahmajāla Sutta, where annihilationist views are grounded in seven bases rather than eight.

The phrase rendered "nirvāṇa in this present life" translates mthong ba'i chos la mya ngan las 'das pa, literally "nirvāṇa in the dharma that is seen," a standard idiom for the view that liberation is attainable and complete within the present visible existence, corresponding to the Pāli diṭṭhadhamma-nibbāna. This is a category of speculative views about the future end, here paradoxically involving the assertion of a present nirvāṇa, which the text treats as falling under views about the final end of things.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text supplied, cutting off after "know that of them." This is a genuine break in the supplied Tibetan and not a translation error.

- The final summary verse is a mnemonic colophon listing the doctrinal positions treated in the sūtra; it breaks off mid-line in the passage provided. The rendering follows the abbreviated verse form conventional for such summaries. The phrase rendered "beings without appearance" reflects the Tibetan འཕྲིན་ལྗང་པ་, likely corresponding to a Sanskrit concept of beings born in a realm without outward appearance or gross form, possibly the asaṅghasatta realm; this is contextually plausible though the exact Sanskrit equivalent is not explicit in the passage. The "Net of Brahmā" (Brahmajāla) clearly identifies this as the Dīgha

Nikāya text of that name, and the closing verse is the uddāna summary standardly appended to such sūtras.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.